

Decent Coaching Classes
VIII CBSE
Academic Conquest - IV
Subject: History — Ruling the Countryside — ANSWER KEY

Section A — MCQ Answers

1. (b) Shah Alam II
2. (b) Warren Hastings
3. (b) Hereditary landowners
4. (b) Thomas Munro
5. (c) North-western India
6. (b) Blue Rebellion

Section B — Very Short Answers

1. What was the Permanent Settlement of 1793?

Introduced by Charles Cornwallis in Bengal, Bihar, Orissa and parts of the Madras Presidency, the Permanent Settlement made zamindars hereditary owners of land while peasants became tenants who lost their rights over common lands like forests and ponds. The revenue amount to be paid by zamindars to the Company was fixed permanently.

2. Name any two cash crops that farmers were forced to grow, and where.

Jute was grown in Bengal and tea in Assam; sugarcane was grown in the United Provinces, wheat and cotton in Punjab, cotton in Maharashtra, and rice in Madras. (Any two with their region are sufficient.)

3. Who were 'lathiyals' and 'gomasthas'?

Lathiyals were the strongmen employed by indigo planters to bully and intimidate peasants. Gomasthas were the planters' agents who collected rent from the ryots; they were beaten up by peasants during the Indigo Rebellion when they came to collect rent.

4. Why did the Company's income remain unstable under Reza Khan's system?

Reza Khan was appointed to collect revenue on the Company's behalf, but corruption and mismanagement in this system caused the revenue amount collected to vary every year, making the Company's income unstable and forcing it to eventually take direct control of revenue collection.

Section C — Short Answers

1. Features and problems of the Permanent Settlement:

Features: Introduced by Cornwallis in 1793 in Bengal, Bihar, Orissa and parts of Madras Presidency; zamindars became hereditary landowners; peasants became tenants losing rights over common lands; the revenue amount was fixed permanently, intended to give the Company a steady income, reduce corruption, and encourage zamindars to invest in improving land.

Problems: The fixed high revenue heavily burdened peasants, as zamindars forced them to grow commercial crops to meet demands, often without payment. Zamindars avoided investing in land improvement themselves and preferred to earn through rents. Many zamindars failed to pay the fixed revenue on time and lost their estates — within 30 years, the Company auctioned many zamindaris. Later, when market prices and agricultural income rose, zamindars benefited but the Company's revenue remained fixed and could not increase.

OR

Ryotwari system and its drawbacks:

Introduced by Thomas Munro in the Bombay and Madras presidencies, Sindh and Assam, the Ryotwari system collected revenue directly from peasants (ryots) instead of through zamindars, with settlement amounts revised every 20 years. It aimed to eliminate intermediaries and reduce exploitation of farmers.

However, the system proved exploitative: the government itself acted as the landowner and imposed very high taxes on peasants. Those who failed to pay on time lost their land and were often forced to borrow from cruel moneylenders, which made the farmers' condition miserable.

2. Nij and ryoti systems of indigo cultivation:

In the nij system, indigo was grown on plantations directly owned by wealthy planters, who bought or rented land from zamindars and hired labourers to cultivate it. This method faced several challenges — fertile land was scarce and available only in small scattered plots, labourers were unavailable during the peak indigo season (which clashed with the rice-farming season), and nij cultivation required many ploughs and bullocks that were difficult to procure. Because of these problems, less than 25 per cent of indigo land was under this system.

Most indigo was cultivated under the ryoti system, in which planters forced farmers to sign contracts, take loans (advances), and use their own fertile land — meant for rice — to grow indigo instead, purchasing the crop at a low, fixed price. Since indigo's deep roots destroyed the fertility of the land and peasants could not repay their loans, they became debt-ridden and impoverished.

3. Causes and course of the Indigo Rebellion of 1859–60:

Causes: The growing poverty of farmers under the ryoti system and the indifference of planters and rulers led to widespread discontent among the ryots of Bengal.

Course: Thousands of ryots refused to grow indigo, refused to pay rents to planters, and attacked indigo factories with swords and spears; women joined using household items like pots and pans. Those who worked for the planters were boycotted, and the planters' agents (gomasthas) were beaten when they came to collect rent. The ryots believed they had the support of zamindars and village headmen, some of whom helped organise the resistance. When the rebellion spread, the government sent the military to protect planters and set up the Indigo Commission, which criticised the planters for using force and allowed ryots to refuse to grow indigo in future, though it asked them to honour existing contracts.

OR

Mahatma Gandhi's role — the Champaran Satyagraha:

After the Indigo Rebellion, indigo production collapsed in Bengal and planters shifted their operations to Bihar (Champaran), where they continued forcing farmers to grow indigo despite the discovery of synthetic dyes damaging their business. When Mahatma Gandhi returned from South Africa, a peasant from Bihar convinced him to visit Champaran to witness the condition of indigo farmers. Gandhi visited the area in 1917 and declared the Champaran Satyagraha against the indigo planters, drawing wider attention and support — including from intellectuals in Calcutta who wrote about the sufferings of the ryots — to the exploitation of indigo farmers.

Section D — Case-Based Answers

(a) Farmers in Nadia district refused to grow indigo because the British planters forced them to grow it instead of rice, leaving them with very little money and deep in debt, so their families struggled to survive.

(b) Raghunath secretly helped the farmers during their revolt by providing them food and shelter, even though he knew it was dangerous to do so.

(c) Raghunath's support shows that zamindars were often caught between obeying the British planters (out of fear of losing their own estates) and sympathising with the suffering farmers. It shows that some zamindars, despite the risk to themselves, chose to secretly support the peasants' resistance against unfair British policies, revealing the difficult and conflicted position zamindars occupied under British rule.